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AI



Cohere's new AI agent platform, North, promises to keep enterprise data secure

AI agent tools promise to siphon out some of the drudgery from daily workflows, but most organizations are hesitant to adopt them yet, harboring a pressing concern: data security. Large enterprises with trade secrets, companies in highly regulated industries, and government agencies have thought more than twice about bringing in AI tools out of concern that their — or worse, their customers' — data could inadvertently be compromised, or used to train foundation models.

Canadian AI firm Cohere is aiming to alleviate those concerns with its new AI agent platform dubbed North, which promises to enable private deployment so that enterprises and governments can keep their and their customers' data safe behind their own firewalls.

"LLMs are only as good as the data they have access to," [Nick Frosst](#), co-founder of Cohere, said during a demo of North. "If we want LLMs to be as useful as possible, they have to access that useful data, and that means they need to be deployed in [the customer's] environment."

Instead of using enterprise cloud platforms like Azure or AWS, Cohere says it can install North on an organization's private infrastructure so that it never sees or interacts with a customer's data. North can run on an organization's on-premise infrastructure, hybrid clouds, VPCs, or air-gapped environments, Frosst said.

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“We can deploy literally on a GPU in a closet that they might have somewhere,” he explained, adding that North was designed to run on as few as two GPUs.

Cohere claims North also includes security protocols like granular access control, agent autonomy policies, continuous red-teaming, and third-party security tests. And it meets international compliance standards like GDPR, SOC-2, and ISO 27001.

More than private deployments

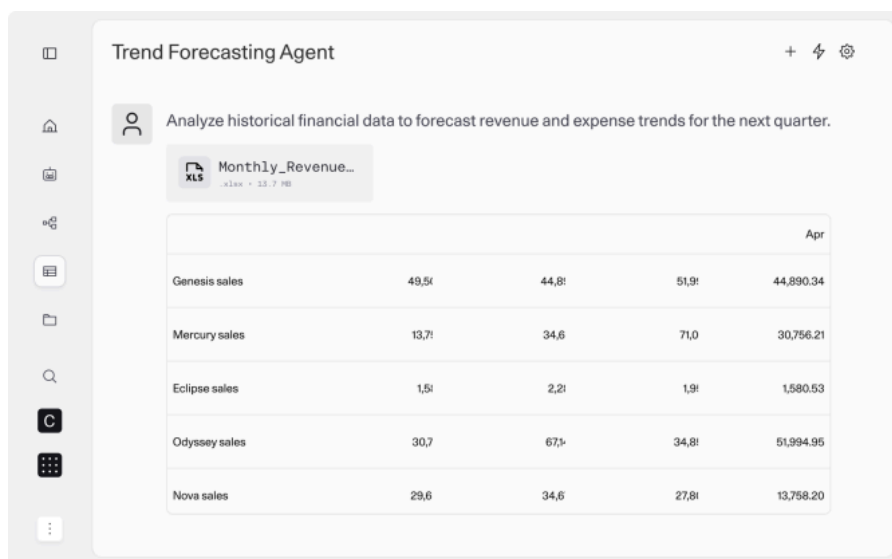


IMAGE CREDITS: COHERE

Cohere, which has so far [raised](#) \$970 million, most recently at a \$5.5 billion valuation, said it has already piloted North with some customers such as RBC, Dell, LG, Ensemble Health Partners, and, as TechCrunch reported last year, [Palantir](#).

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North mirrors many AI agent platforms right out of the box. Its chief features are chat and search, which let users get answers to customer support inquiries; summarize meeting transcripts, write marketing copy, and access information from both internal resources and the web. Frosst added that all responses include citations and “reasoning” chains of thought so employees can audit and verify the output.

The chat and search functions are powered by existing Cohere technology, like Command (its family of generative AI models) and Compass (its multimodal search tech stack). Frosst said North is powered by a variant of its Command model that is trained for enterprise reasoning.

“It goes beyond just Q&A and gets into doing work for you. So, [North] has a bunch of asset creation. It can make tables, it can make documents, it can make slideshows. It can do a bunch of market research,” Frosst said.

It's worth noting that in May, [Cohere acquired Ottogrid](#), a Vancouver-based platform that develops enterprise tools for automating high-level market research.

Like other AI agent platforms, North can connect to existing workplace tools like Gmail, Slack,

Salesforce, Outlook, and Linear, and integrate with any Model Context Protocol (MCP) servers to access industry-specific or in-house applications.

“As you build confidence by chatting to the model, there’s like a smooth transition that happens between using this as an augmentation to using it as an automation,” Frosst said.

Correction: A previous version of this article misstated Frosst’s title. We regret the error.

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Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch, where she covers Tesla and Elon Musk’s broader empire,...

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TRANSPORTATION





Rivian elects Cohere's CEO to its board in latest signal the EV maker is bullish on AI

Kirsten Korosec — 5:27 PM PDT · April 21, 2025

Aidan Gomez, the co-founder and CEO of generative AI startup Cohere, has joined the board of EV maker Rivian, [according to a regulatory filing](#). The appointment is the latest sign that Rivian sees promises in applying AI to its own venture while positioning itself as a software leader — and even provider — within the automotive industry.

IMAGE CREDITS:

Rivian increased the size of the board and elected Gomez, whose term will expire in 2026, according to the filing.

Gomez has had a long career as a data scientist and AI expert. He launched Cohere in 2019 with co-founders Nick Frosst and Ivan Zhang with a focus on training AI foundation models for enterprises. The generative AI startup sells its services to companies such as Oracle and Notion.

Prior to starting Cohere, Gomez was a researcher at Google Brain, the deep learning division at Google led by Nobel Prize winner Geoffrey Hinton. Gomez is also known for “Attention Is All You Need,” a 2017 technical paper he co-authored that laid the foundation for many of the most capable generative AI models today.

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Gomez’s skill set could be particularly useful for Rivian as the EV maker navigates a new [\\$5.8 billion joint venture](#) with Volkswagen Group to develop software. Under the joint venture, Rivian will share its electrical architecture expertise with Volkswagen Group — including its many brands — and is expected to license existing intellectual property rights to the joint venture.

It’s possible the joint venture will sell its tech to other companies in the future.

Rivian has also been working on an AI assistant for its EVs since 2023, Rivian’s chief software officer, Wassym Bensaid, told TechCrunch during an interview in March. The AI work, which is specifically on the orchestration layer or framework for an AI assistant, sits outside the joint venture with VW, Bensaid mentioned at the time.

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Gomez’s expertise in AI and as a data scientist is clearly attractive to Rivian founder and CEO RJ Scaringe, who

noted in a statement that his “thinking and expertise will support Rivian as we integrate new, cutting-edge technologies into our products, services, and manufacturing.”

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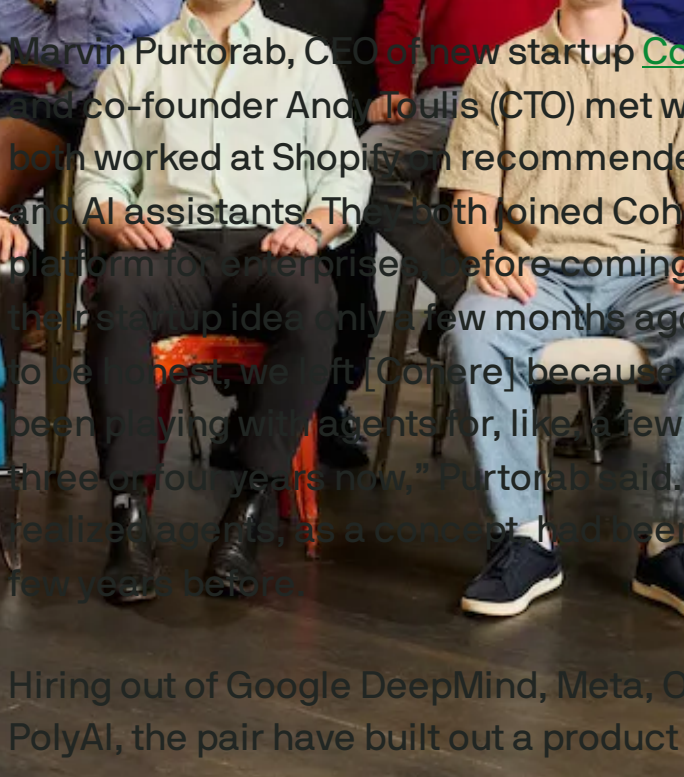
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Marvin Purtorab, CEO of new startup [Convergence](#), and co-founder Andy Toulis (CTO) met while they both worked at Shopify on recommender systems and AI assistants. They both joined Cohere, the AI platform for enterprises, before coming up with their startup idea only a few months ago. “I mean, to be honest, we left [Cohere] because ... we had been playing with agents for, like, a few years, like three or four years now,” Purtorab said. They’d realized agents, as a concept, had been too early a few years before.

Hiring out of Google DeepMind, Meta, OpenAI, and PolyAI, the pair have built out a product in barely a few months, garnering significant interest from investors.

IMAGE CREDITS: CONVERGENCE AI

As of today, most agents are designed for specific workflows. Convergence’s “Proxy” agent will work across a number of tasks, with the idea that it acquires skills in the same way a human might by giving it so-called “long-term memory.” That’s via what’s been dubbed by some as “Large Meta Learning Models” (LMLM). These are trained to acquire the skill of learning on their own.

Convergence raised a \$12 million pre-seed round led by Balderton Capital. Salesforce Ventures and Shopify Ventures also participated in the round, and will be deployed to develop novel models that power Proxy assistants.

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In a statement, James Wise, partner at Balderton Capital, said: “Few people have the experience and skill that Marvin and Andy have, which makes them well-placed to take on the complex technical challenge of a product like Proxy.”

Human users get paired with Proxy agents, which can learn tasks and workflows, freeing the human worker up to do more decision-making than the “grunt work.”

Purtorab said: “If you look at the landscape right now, there’s a lot of companies building these, like ‘narrow’ agents: a sales agent, or an HR agent, or a finance ops agent. Our view is to take a different approach. We’re trying to build the foundations for the first general class of agents that can, depending on the user, delineate into any type of agent you need that does the things for you that you, personally, in your job don’t want to do. And we think that’s kind of a better approach, because we just don’t really see the world of the future of everyone having 1,000 of these different little tools. Over time, things are going to consolidate, and I think that’s where we will come in.”

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The strategy is to create consumer agents, but then use those to inform how they train agents in the enterprise. “Consumers are using it more for, like, online shopping like groceries and recipes. On the enterprise side, people are using it to do sales ops. Like, enter a lot of stuff into Salesforce, and keep track of it. Or talent operations, like, keeping track of applicants for a job.”

So are they using consumers as sort of guinea pigs for the enterprise? “That’s would be one way to phrase it. Consumers have a lot of simpler and much broader kind of use cases and it helps us get feedback quicker, right?” Purtorab said.

With all that said, what do they make of the kinds of announcements that Salesforce is making, around agents? “I was at Dreamforce last week, and I think that it’s the right direction. But I do think that they’re also going much more in the direction of, like these very narrow agents that focus on one specific task... Right now you don’t have time to wait another six to 12 months for models to develop a bit better.”

Right now the company is in closed beta with testers, but it should open up shortly.

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Google Cloud teams up with NLP startup Cohere on multiyear partnership around TPUs

Ron Miller — 7:45 AM PST · November 17, 2021

[Google Cloud](#) announced a multiyear partnership with [Cohere](#), an early-stage startup that is building a natural language processing platform to make it easier for developers to build natural language processing models into applications. The solution requires a fair amount of infrastructure resources to pull off, and Google Cloud Platform (GCP) is going to provide them under the terms of this deal.

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The two companies are also planning a go-to-market effort together, giving Cohere a big lift as a startup to help jumpstart usage and sales with the power of the GCP sales team.

Google Cloud CEO Thomas Kurian said that Cohere offers a great use case for Google Cloud Tensor Processing Unit (TPUs) chips that builds on work Google has been doing in-house.

“First of all, this is a perfect example of a technology that we built at Google for our own use, these high-scale TPUs. We’re now making them available in the cloud to other platform companies,” Kurian told me. “But here is an example [with Cohere] where they find that the ability to use and build models and train them on TPUs provides them very differentiated capability.”

Aidan Gomez, co-founder and CEO at Cohere, who previously worked at [Google Brain](#), said his company is trying to build an NLP solution that makes all of this advanced technology available to any developer. “We scrape the data to train these big models, we train them on massive TPU pods, and we optimize them because they’re extremely large, and want them to fit the latency tolerances of pretty much any production system,” Gomez explained.

He said that by optimizing the workloads, Cohere can open up access to all of this advanced technology, enabling developers to access the models and start building NLP-based solutions based on the models that Cohere is providing. Kurian said that he is starting to see this shift from the text-based UI to one that’s more driven by natural language interactions, and Cohere is a good example of how to make this happen.

“If you look at the state of the art, the way that the vast majority of people use computers is through

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graphical user interfaces or screens. I don't think that people want to experience computers through just one sense, which is the sense of sight," Kurian said. "They want to interact with computers in more ways and they want to interact in more natural ways. So language is the next big phase of evolution of the way that people interact with systems."

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It's not every day that you see the CEO of one of the big three cloud platforms get on a call to discuss a partnership with a startup, but Kurian believes this is a particularly compelling and creative example of TPU usage. "If you actually use the Cohere technology, you will find that it works very elegantly because of the combination of the software that Aidan's team has built and the computational infrastructure that TPUs provide."

Cohere was founded in 2019 by Gomez, Nick Frosst and Ivan Zhang in Toronto. The company has raised \$40 million from Index Ventures, Radical Ventures, Section 32, and a who's who of industry AI angels

Including Geoffrey Hinton and Fei-Fei Li, among others.

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